Lesson 8 — The Line We Share

Part 1 of 12: Passage — The Line We Share

Level: B1 (eighth step)

About 20 minutes · this part carries a sheet and audio

> How to do the listening. The same rule as every lesson so far: the student listens twice with no text, then reads. Audio files: `01-passage.mp3` first, then the other parts in order. Part `05-would-and-if.mp3` is new — the contracted 'd for would and had, and the weak if.

1.1 Before listening (2 minutes, Arabic is fine here)

1. If your connection failed in the middle of a class, what would you do?
2. What do you and your neighbours share, and what rules do you keep about it?
3. If you had one thing to make studying easier, what would you choose, and why?

1.4 Now read the passage

Passage: The Line We Share (516 words)

The connection comes into the street on one line, and everything else hangs off it. From a box on the third floor it goes up to an antenna on the roof, across to a second antenna on the roof opposite, and from there into four more flats. Seven families, one uplink.

[A] A mesh works like that: every point relays the signal on to the next, so a street can share one line instead of buying seven. No single family here could afford the line on its own, and together they can. It is cheap and it is clever, and it has one weakness that everybody who uses it learns in the first week. If the uplink fails, nothing after it works. The antennas are all fine. There is simply nothing to pass on.

Aya has a class at eight on Monday evenings — thirty students, a teacher in another city, and a slide deck that has to load. If the line is slow, the video stops and the voice survives, which she can work with. If the line goes down, the lesson is over for all thirty of them, because nobody has a second way in.

[B] So she prepares for both evenings at once. She downloads the slides on Sunday night, when the line is quiet and the latency is low, and she keeps the last four weeks of recordings on the laptop. If the class fails on Monday, she will read the slides and send her questions as messages. If it does not fail, she has lost nothing but twenty minutes of a quiet Sunday.

The families have rules, which is what makes a shared line reliable at all. Nobody sends anything large between seven and ten. If somebody has to, they say so first. If two people ignore that on the same evening, everyone knows within a minute, because the latency climbs and every class in the street begins to stutter.

[C] Aya is careful about what she says she would do with a faster line, because a wish is an easy thing to turn into an excuse. If she had a reliable fifty megabits, she says, she would stop planning around the

connection and spend that hour on the work itself. She would also stop apologising at the start of every call.

[D] There is an application open on the laptop that she has been filling in for three weeks: a university in Spain, an exchange place with a small scholarship attached, and a language requirement she is four months away from meeting. If she is accepted, she will go for one semester. If she is not, she will apply again in the spring. Either way the English has to be finished, so the English gets done. That part is hers, and it is the one part the line cannot reach.

The tower on the roof is a length of pipe, two brackets and a cable tie, and a neighbour put it up in an afternoon. If it comes down in the next storm, they will put it up again. They have done it twice.

1.5 Read aloud

Read the passage aloud once and record it. Watch the tune of the conditional sentences: the if-clause rises, the main clause falls. Read three of them aloud twice, listening for the shape rather than the words.